INTELLIGENCE ASSESSMENT

Houthi Threat Posture & Covert Action Options in the Context of the 2026 Iran War

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From: Director of the Central Intelligence Agency
To: The President; NSC Principals Committee
Subject: Houthi Threat Assessment, Iranian C2 Disruption, and Updated Covert Action Options
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Prepared by: Near East and South Asia Mission Center (NESAMC)
Coordination: DIA (concurs); NSA/CSS (concurs with caveats); NGA (concurs)

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I. KEY JUDGMENTS

The following represent the consensus assessment of NESAMC, coordinated with DIA and NSA. Confidence levels follow IC Analytic Standards (ICD 203).

KJ-1: The Houthis will resume attacks on Red Sea shipping within 4-8 weeks absent diplomatic intervention. The March 28 attack on Israel is a deliberate escalatory step. Houthi leadership has stated closing Bab el-Mandeb is 'among our options.' Operational capability is INTACT despite the August 2025 cabinet decapitation.

Confidence: HIGH. OSINT and pattern analysis of prior escalation cycles.

KJ-2: The Iran-Houthi C2 link is DEGRADED but NOT SEVERED. Khamenei's assassination and 75%+ missile launcher destruction reduced Tehran's operational direction. However, Houthis retain autonomous capability -- demonstrated by their one-month strategic pause before resuming on their own timeline.

Confidence: MODERATE. Behavioral pattern analysis and allied HUMINT.

KJ-3: A dual Hormuz/Bab el-Mandeb closure carries 35-55% probability within 8-12 weeks if the war continues. Saudi Arabia's Yanbu reroute makes Bab el-Mandeb the most strategically important maritime chokepoint in the world.

Confidence: MODERATE. Reflects uncertainty about Houthi-Iranian coordination.

KJ-4: Houthi leadership is primarily driven by organizational survival, not ideological solidarity with Iran. The one-month pause while Hezbollah and PMF immediately joined indicates al-Houthi is calculating U.S. retaliatory strike risk. The May 2025 deal and Saudi understandings are restraining factors.

Confidence: HIGH. Multiple allied HUMINT sources and behavioral indicators converge.

KJ-5: CIA HUMINT collection against Houthi targets has degraded ~45%. NCS requests Supplemental MON to expand operations.

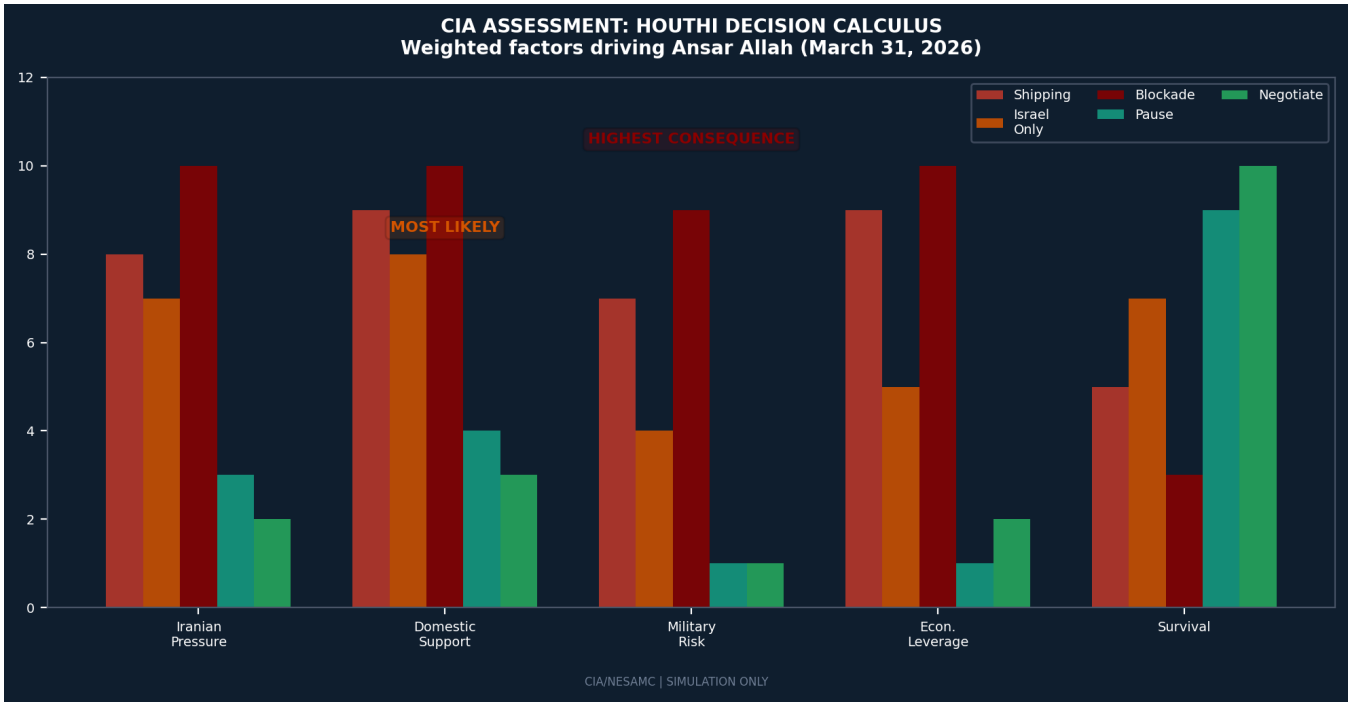
Confidence: HIGH (internal assessment).

II. INTELLIGENCE ASSESSMENT: HOUTHI THREAT POSTURE

A. Adversary Decision Calculus

NESAMC assesses the Houthi leadership is weighing five courses of action. The March 28 attack on Israel -- first since October 2025 -- is a calibrated signal: re-entering against Israel while NOT yet attacking Red Sea shipping. The Houthis attacked 100+ vessels between Nov 2023-Oct 2025, sinking four and killing nine. Withholding maritime capability for a full month while attacking Israel directly suggests deliberate calculation, not absence of capability. Restraining factors: (1) May 2025 Trump ceasefire -- risk of resumed U.S. strikes; (2) Saudi understandings protecting Yanbu reroute; (3) Ford CSG availability; (4) STC southern threat. These factors are time-limited.

Appendix A: Decision Calculus

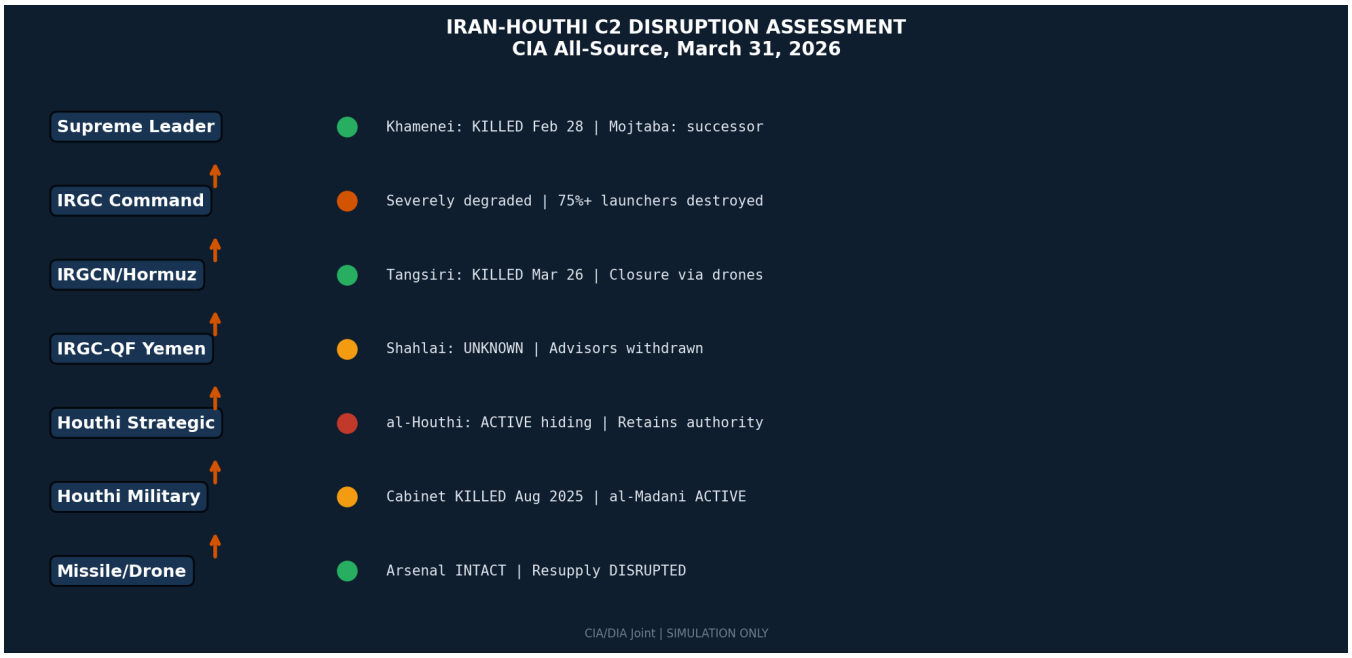


Five scenarios by weighted factors. 'Israel Only' most likely near-term. 'Shipping Attacks' rises past Week 8. SIMULATION ONLY.

B. Iran-Houthi C2 Disruption

Khamenei assassination created most significant C2 disruption since 1979. Mojtaba's succession confirms hardline continuity. 75%+ of Iranian missile launchers destroyed. IRGC-QF Yemen Division operationally compromised -- advisors withdrawn, communication now mediated through Omani/Lebanese intermediaries. Latency increased; Tehran's real-time influence reduced.

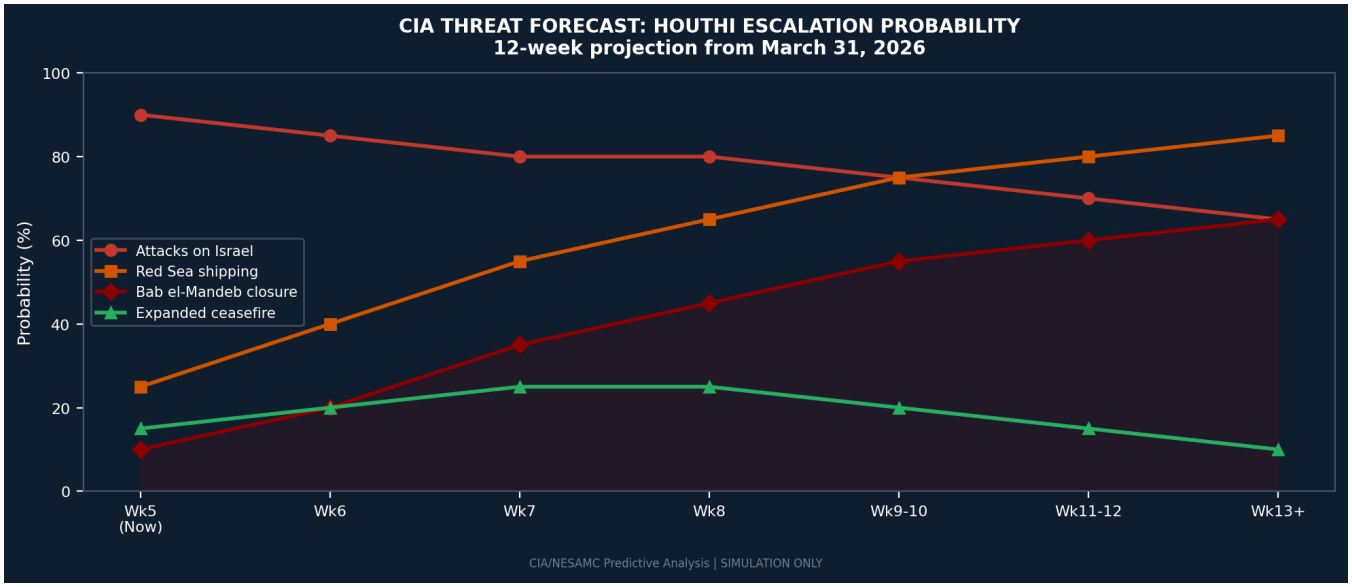
Appendix B: C2 Chain Disruption



Top of chain severely disrupted; bottom (missile/drone capability) INTACT. CIA/DIA Joint Assessment. SIMULATION ONLY.

III. THREAT FORECAST

Appendix C: 12-Week Escalation Probability

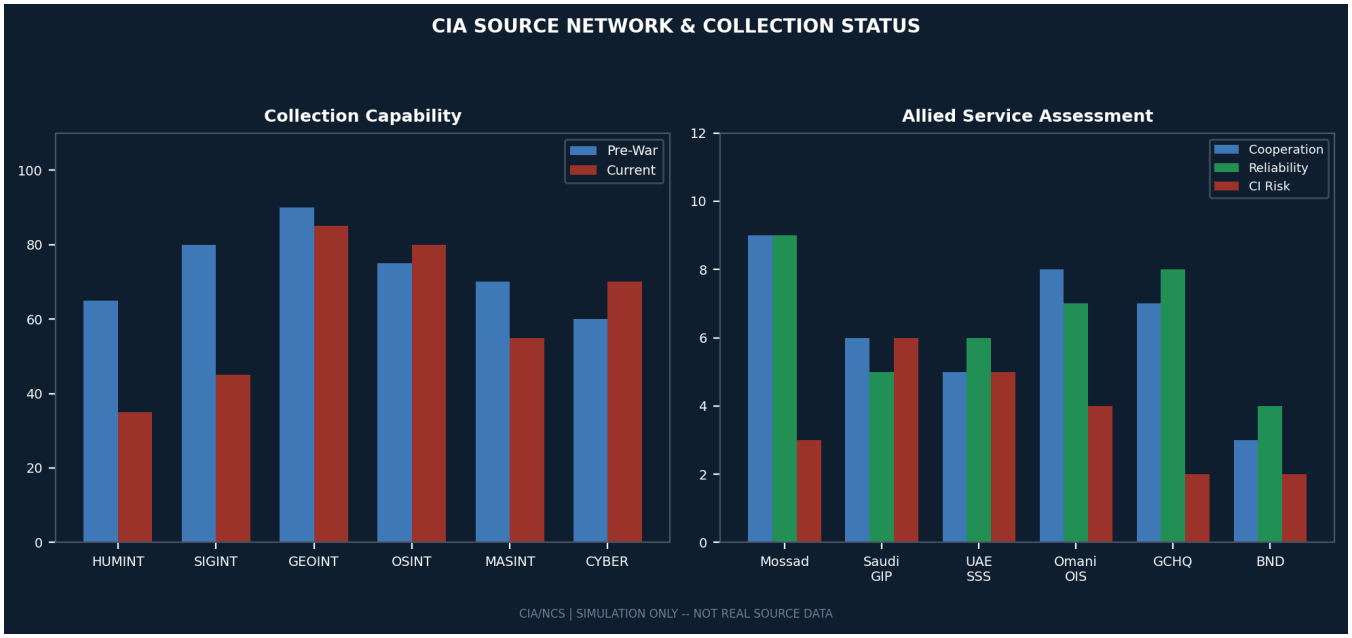


Red Sea shipping crosses 50% by Week 7 (mid-May). Bab el-Mandeb closure crosses 50% by Week 9 (early June). Diplomatic window: 4-6 weeks. SIMULATION ONLY.

IV. COLLECTION POSTURE & SOURCE NETWORK

HUMINT degraded ~45%: IRGC-QF withdrawal, Houthi CI crackdowns (informant executions, restricted movement), wartime disruption. SIGINT degraded ~44%: senior Houthis off phones, in-person only. GEOINT near-optimal 85%. OSINT slightly improved.

Appendix D: Source Network



Left: Collection by INT. Right: Allied services. Mossad highest but Iran-focused. Omani OIS most critical for Houthi diplomacy. Saudi GIP constrained by Yanbu priority. SIMULATION ONLY.

V. COVERT ACTION OPTIONS -- WARTIME UPDATE

â■º **Alpha -- Expanded Omani Channel (PRIORITY):** Negotiate expanded ceasefire covering Bab el-Mandeb. NCS co-locate OIS Muscat within 72 hours. No Finding required. Risk: LOW.

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READY TO EXECUTE.
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â■º **Bravo -- CYBERCOM Drone Disruption (PRIORITY):** GPS spoofing of Houthi drones. Stocks finite with resupply disrupted. Presidential auth under PPD-20. Risk: LOW.

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CMF target package ready.
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â■º **Charlie -- Saudi Maritime Patrol Intel (PRIORITY):** GEOINT/SIGINT to Saudi naval forces for Bab el-Mandeb. Title 10 sharing. Risk: LOW-MOD.

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Saudi GIP receptive.
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â■º **Delta -- Houthi Back-Channel (NEW):** Direct communication with al-Houthi circle via GIP. Assess Bab el-Mandeb neutrality deal. Supplemental MON required. Risk: MODERATE.

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NCS requesting authority.
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â■º **Echo -- Iran Domestic Pressure (WARTIME):** Already executing under wartime MON. Regime instability reduces proxy coordination. Increases Houthi autonomy and negotiation amenability.

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ACTIVE.
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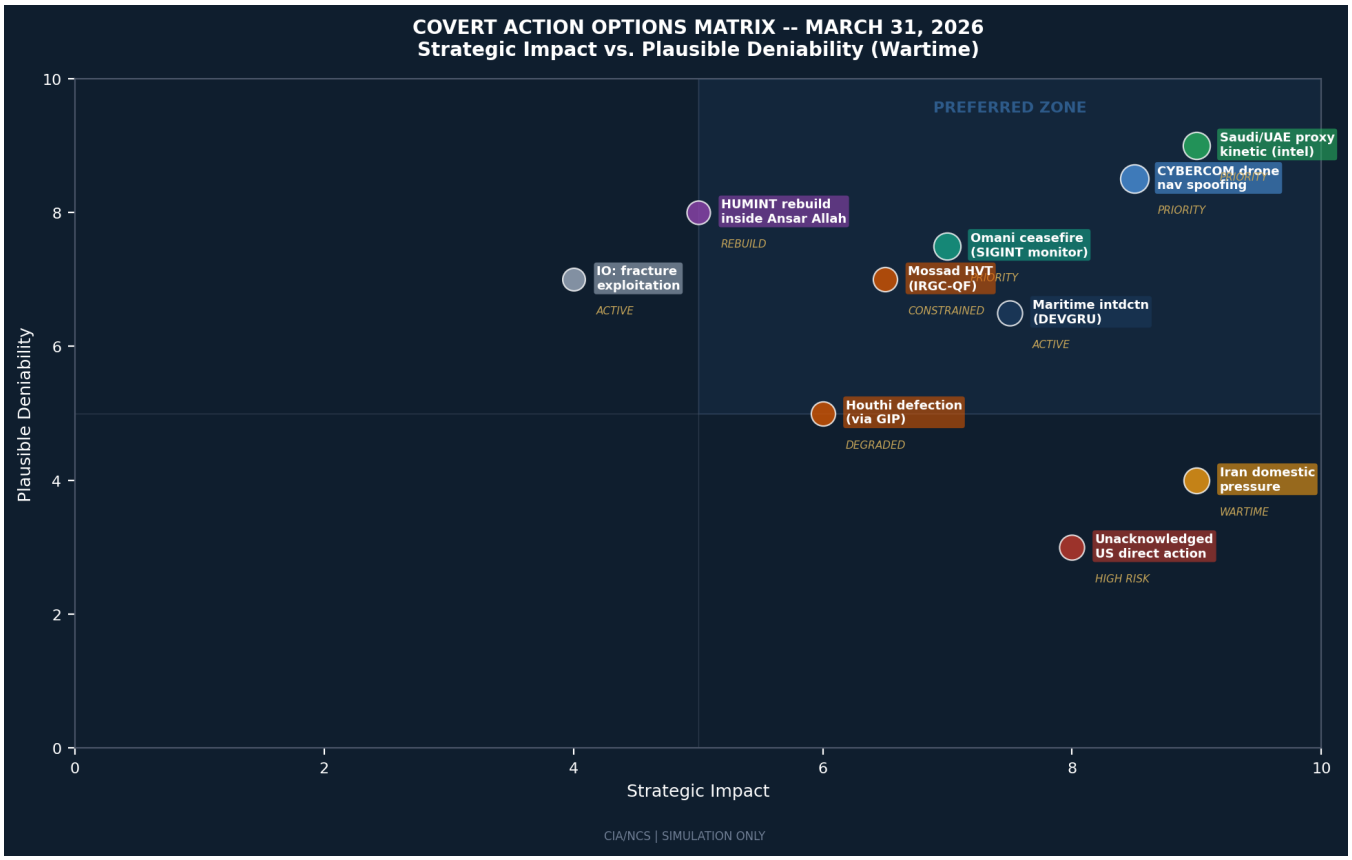
Appendix E: Covert Matrix



Three PRIORITY options in preferred zone. Wartime status labels. SIMULATION ONLY.

VI. COUNTERINTELLIGENCE CONCERNS

â■º **Houthi CI Intensification:** Post-Aug 2025 -- raids on UN agencies, informant executions, leadership rural dispersal. At least two HUMINT ops compromised [simulated].

â■º **Iranian Cyber Retaliation:** IRGC-CEC retaliatory capability. CYBERCOM ops (Bravo) if attributed could trigger retaliation.

â■º **Allied Reliability:** Saudi GIP/UAE SSS now transactional. Compartmentalized handling recommended.

â■º **OPSEC:** March 2025 Signal chat weaknesses not remediated. All Yemen/Houthi covert planning restricted to JWICS.

VII. PRIORITY INTELLIGENCE REQUIREMENTS

â■º **PIR-1 (CRITICAL):** Houthi thresholds for shipping attacks / Bab el-Mandeb closure.

â■º **PIR-2 (CRITICAL):** IRGC-QF communication status with Houthi command. Directing or autonomous?

â■º **PIR-3 (HIGH):** Houthi anti-ship inventory status. Can they sustain 2024-intensity campaign?

â■º **PIR-4 (HIGH):** Is al-Houthi open to expanded ceasefire? Minimum conditions?

â■º **PIR-5 (MOD):** STC threat diverting Houthi resources?

VIII. DIRECTOR'S RECOMMENDATION

â■º **IMMEDIATE (1-7d):** Activate Omani channel (Alpha). Window: 4-6 weeks. NCS Muscat 72h.

â■º **NEAR-TERM (7-21d):** Execute CYBERCOM (Bravo) + Saudi patrol (Charlie). Non-kinetic deterrence.

â■º **MEDIUM-TERM (21-45d):** Supplemental MON for back-channel (Delta). Al-Houthi's survival calculus suggests openness.

â■º **CONTINGENCY:** If Houthis resume shipping attacks, only rapid options are renewed US or Israeli strikes. Both high escalation risk. Director recommends exhausting diplomatic/covert options first.

Respectfully submitted,

Director of the Central Intelligence Agency

CIA Headquarters, Langley, Virginia

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[1] Drafted with AI assistance (Claude Opus 4.6, Anthropic). Retroactive simulation for academic purposes. All information from public sources. No real intelligence represented.